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# Ethics

Moral Relativism vs. Moral Objectivism

| INSTRUCTOR | UNIVERSITY | CODE |
|---|---|---|
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| **FACULTY** | **DEPARTMENT** | **WEEK** |
| **Humanities** | **Philosophy** | **2** |
| **DISCIPLINE** | **TYPE** | **LEVEL** |
| **Philosophy** | **Debate/Discussion Sessions** | **Undergraduate** |

## THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

- Moral Relativism
- Moral Objectivism
- Meta-ethics
- Normative Ethics
- Counter-argumentation

## NAVIGATING THE FOUNDATIONS OF META-ETHICS: RELATIVISM VS. OBJECTIVISM

SESSION OVERVIEW

**Duration:** 60 minutes

**Learning Objectives:**

- Distinguish between the ontological claims of moral objectivism and moral relativism.
- Analyze the implications of cultural moral variation on normative ethical frameworks.
- Evaluate the strength of arguments regarding the universality of human rights.
- Construct and defend a coherent position on the nature of moral truth.

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## BACKGROUND BRIEFING

The debate over moral status concerns whether moral judgments are true or false independent of human belief (Objectivism) or if they are relative to the culture or individual (Relativism). This session challenges students to move beyond surface-level opinions to evaluate the meta-ethical underpinnings of our moral landscape. Participants should prepare to defend their assigned stance using formal philosophical reasoning.

## MOTION / DISCUSSION TOPIC

**Question:** Is moral truth fundamentally grounded in objective reality, or is it a social construct contingent upon cultural context?

## POSITIONS & PERSPECTIVES

### Position A: In Favour of Moral Objectivism

**Key Arguments:**

- **Moral Realism:** Moral facts exist independently of human opinion, similar to mathematical truths. This ensures that moral claims have a truth value that can be discovered through reason.
- **Universal Human Rights:** If morality were entirely relative, the condemnation of atrocities like genocide would be impossible. Objectivism provides a firm basis for asserting that certain actions are inherently wrong regardless of cultural consensus.
- **Moral Progress:** The concept of moral progress implies that societies can improve their moral standards over time. This is only coherent if there is an objective standard against which progress is measured.
- **Rational Consistency:** Objective morality provides a stable framework for resolving interpersonal and intercultural conflicts. Without it, moral discourse collapses into mere preference signaling.

**Relevant Data/Theory:**

- **Platonic Realism:** The theory that moral values exist as abstract, eternal entities.
- **Intuitionism:** G.E. Mooreś view that moral properties are non-natural but nonetheless real and discoverable.
- **Human Rights Theory:** The philosophical grounding of universal rights found in Kantian ethics and the Universal Declaration of Human Rights.

**Potential Counterarguments:**

- **Cultural Diversity:** Critics point to the vast differences in moral codes across cultures as evidence against objectivity. Objectivists respond that disagreement on values does not imply the non-existence of objective truth, just as disagreement on science does not invalidate it.
- **Epistemic Access:** Critics argue we cannot access objective moral truths. Objectivists argue that our fallibility in knowing moral truth does not mean that truth is absent.

### Position B: In Favour of Moral Relativism

**Key Arguments:**

- **Cultural Diversity:** The empirical evidence of widespread disagreement on moral values suggests that morality is a product of social conditioning. Different cultures develop different rules based on their unique survival needs and historical trajectories.
- **The Diversity Thesis:** This argument posits that because there is no universal agreement on moral codes, moral truth is essentially relative to the observer. It promotes tolerance by discouraging cultural imperialism.
- **Social Constructionism:** Morality functions as a social glue that facilitates cooperation within a specific community. Its validity is therefore local, as it serves the needs of that specific social group.

- **Anti-Dogmatism:** Relativism prevents the imposition of one groups moral values onto others. It encourages a humble approach to ethical judgment, acknowledging that no culture possesses an exclusive claim to moral truth.

**Relevant Data/Theory:**

- **Cultural Relativism:** The anthropological perspective popularized by Ruth Benedict and Franz Boas.
- **Gilbert Harmans Relativism:** The theory that moral judgments are relative to the moral framework of the agent.
- **Emotivism:** The meta-ethical view that moral statements are expressions of emotion rather than factual claims.

**Potential Counterarguments:**

- **The Problem of Reformers:** If morality is defined by current social consensus, then moral reformers like Martin Luther King Jr. were technically immoral at the time. Relativists argue that reformers are simply introducing new, more adaptive norms that the society adopts.
- **Moral Paralysis:** Critics claim relativism leads to nihilism. Relativists respond that we can still hold strong local values without needing to claim they are universal truths.

## SESSION FLOW

| | |
|---|---|
| **Opening & Framing** (10') | The instructor provides a concise overview of the meta-ethical landscape, defining key terms such as cognitive vs. non-cognitive theories. |
| **Position Statements** (10') | Each side presents their core arguments, outlining the foundational logic of their respective positions. |
| **Open Debate** (30') | Students engage in structured dialogue, applying theoretical concepts to concrete ethical dilemmas such as human rights or cultural practices. |
| **Synthesis & Debrief** (10') | The group identifies points of convergence and divergence, summarizing the implications of the debate for their broader understanding of ethics. |

## GROUND RULES

- *Critique the argument, not the person.*
- *Listen actively to understand the logic before formulating a rebuttal.*
- *Base claims on theoretical frameworks rather than personal anecdotes.*
- *Maintain an environment of intellectual humility and open-mindedness.*
- *Ensure all participants have an opportunity to contribute their perspectives.*

# INSTRUCTOR COPY — FACILITATION NOTES

**INSTRUCTOR NOTES**

The primary goal is to shift students from arguing about specific moral issues to arguing about the source of moral authority itself. A common pitfall is students conflating 'tolerance' with 'relativism'; ensure they understand that one can be tolerant while still believing in objective moral truths. Use the 'Synthesis' phase to highlight that both sides struggle with the same problem: how to account for both human diversity and the intuitive feeling that some things are simply 'wrong.' End by emphasizing that the debate is a foundational exercise in meta-ethical literacy.

**If Discussion Stalls:**

- *How would you respond to the claim that moral progress is impossible under relativism?*
- *If you had to define one universal moral rule that applies to all humans, what would it be and why?*
- *Does the existence of cultural disagreement necessarily imply that there is no objective truth?*
- *How does our reliance on social media influence our perception of moral truth?*

# DEBATE RUBRIC: MORAL OBJECTIVISM VS. MORAL RELATIVISM

## Argument Quality & Reasoning (30%)

| 5 | 4 | 3 | 2 | 1 |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Arguments are sophisticated, logically rigorous, and provide a compelling, nuanced defense of the position that addresses the fundamental nature of moral truth. | Arguments are logically coherent, well-structured, and demonstrate a clear understanding of the core tension between objective reality and social construction. | Arguments are generally logical and clear, though they may lack depth or struggle to fully articulate the ontological implications of the chosen stance. | Arguments are present but rely on logical fallacies or lack clear connection to the debate between objectivism and relativism. | Arguments regarding the nature of moral truth are incoherent, unclear, or fail to address the motion entirely. |

Score: _____ Notes: _____

## Use of Evidence & Theory (30%)

| 5 | 4 | 3 | 2 | 1 |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Demonstrates mastery of the material by seamlessly integrating complex ethical theories and diverse cultural evidence to provide robust support for the argument. | Accurately applies core concepts of moral objectivism or relativism to support claims with relevant, well-chosen examples. | Uses relevant ethical theories or cultural examples to support claims, though the connection to the motion is sometimes superficial. | Mentions course concepts or examples but applies them inaccurately or in a way that does not support the argument regarding moral truth. | Fails to incorporate relevant ethical theories or examples; arguments are based purely on personal opinion. |

Score: _____ Notes: _____

## Engagement with Counterarguments (25%)

| 5 | 4 | 3 | 2 | 1 |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Demonstrates a deep understanding of the opposing position by proactively addressing its strongest challenges and providing a sophisticated, nuanced rebuttal. | Substantively addresses the strongest points of the opposing side, providing a clear and logical rebuttal or integration of the counter-perspective. | Identifies and addresses the opposing view, but the rebuttal is weak or fails to account for the strongest points of the counter-argument. | Acknowledges the opposing view but fails to engage with it, or dismisses it without addressing its core philosophical challenge. | Ignores opposing viewpoints entirely or fails to recognize the existence of an alternative perspective on moral truth. |

Score: _____ Notes: _____

## Synthesis & Insight (15%)

| 5 | 4 | 3 | 2 | 1 |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Provides profound insight by synthesizing the debate into a broader ethical context, demonstrating an exceptional grasp of the complexities and implications of moral truth. | Demonstrates a nuanced understanding of the debate, effectively connecting the motion to broader ethical implications and the complexity of moral truth. | Connects the debate to broader ethical implications, showing a developing understanding of how these concepts impact normative frameworks. | Makes a basic connection to the week's subject but fails to demonstrate insight beyond the surface level of the motion. | Fails to connect the debate to broader ethical implications; remains trapped in a simplistic binary framing. |

Score: _____ Notes: _____